

Leonardo then applied his conclusions to designs for machines.

One flying machine, called an air-screw, had a spiral blade. When turned, the blade would lift the machine into the air in much the same way that a modern helicopter blade lifts a helicopter. The blade, 15 ft (4.5 m) wide, would be made of linen and covered in starch to stiffen it and block pores in the fabric. Though he never built the machine, Leonardo was convinced it would have worked.

If Leonardo's ideas had been published in his lifetime, his fame would have been even greater. But he kept these ideas to himself, shut up in his notebooks, and the world ended up waiting hundreds of years until other scientists made similar discoveries for themselves.



Reconstruction of Leonardo's design for an air-screw